

Introduction to Excel

Interface • Workbook • Worksheet • Cells • Ribbon

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Ribbon tabs

What is Microsoft Excel?

A spreadsheet program used to store, organise, calculate and analyse data — especially numbers.

Use	Example
Calculations & formulas	Monthly expenses, averages
Storing data in tables	Student marks, employee records
Charts & graphs	Bar chart of sales, pie chart of expenses
Budgets & finance	Salary sheets, profit and loss
Data analysis	Sorting, filtering, finding patterns

EXCEL VS WORD

Word
Documents
Paragraphs
Letters

Excel
Numbers
Tables
Formulas

REMEMBER

The right tool matters — use Excel for numbers and data, Word for written documents.

Opening Excel

1.2 · Theory

1 · Start menu

- 1 Click the Start button
- 2 Type Excel in the search box
- 3 Click Microsoft Excel in the results

2 · Open an existing file

- 1 Open File Explorer
- 2 Find a file ending in .xlsx
- 3 Double-click the file to open it in Excel

3 · From the Start Screen

- 1 Excel opens with the Start Screen
- 2 Click Blank Workbook to start fresh
- 3 Or click a Recent file to reopen it

FILE TYPE

An Excel file is called a workbook and ends in .xlsx.

Practice 1.2: Open Excel

Practice · 1 of 4

GOAL

Open Excel from the Start menu and start a blank workbook.

- 1 Click the **Start** button.
- 2 Type **Excel**. Press **Enter**.
- 3 Click **Blank Workbook** on the Start Screen.
- 4 Look at the Title Bar at the top.

YOU SHOULD SEE

- The Excel window opens
- A blank grid appears
- The Title Bar shows the workbook name (for example Book1)

Key vocabulary

Term	Meaning	Example
Workbook	The whole Excel file, saved as .xlsx. It can contain many sheets.	Book1.xlsx
Worksheet	A single spreadsheet tab inside a workbook.	Sheet1
Cell	One single box in the grid — where you type data.	B3
Row	A horizontal line of cells, numbered 1, 2, 3...	Row 5
Column	A vertical line of cells, labelled A, B, C...	Column C
Cell reference	The address of a cell: column + row.	B3
Active cell	The currently selected cell. It has a green border.	—
Range	A group of cells.	A1:C5
Formula	A calculation that starts with an = sign.	=A1+B1
Formula Bar	The bar above the grid that shows the content of the active cell.	—

Practice 1.3: Cells and references

Practice · 2 of 4

GOAL

Find a cell by its address and see what the Formula Bar shows.

- 1 Click cell **B3**.
- 2 Check: the Name Box shows **B3**.
- 3 Type your name in **B3**. Press **Enter**.
- 4 Click **B3** again. Look at the Formula Bar.
- 5 Click the column **B** header.

YOU SHOULD SEE

- The Name Box shows B3
- Your name is in B3
- The Formula Bar shows your name
- Column B is highlighted

The Excel interface

Part	Location	What it does
Title Bar	Very top	Shows the workbook name and Microsoft Excel
Quick Access Toolbar	Top-left	Save, Undo, Redo — always visible
Ribbon	Below the Title Bar	All commands in tabs: Home, Insert, Data...
Name Box	Left of the Formula Bar	Shows the active cell address — type here to jump
Formula Bar	Right of the Name Box	Shows the content of the active cell
Column headers	Letters across the top	A, B, C... click to select the entire column
Row headers	Numbers on the left	1, 2, 3... click to select the entire row
Sheet tabs	Bottom of the screen	One tab = one worksheet — right-click to rename
Status Bar	Bottom of the screen	Shows Sum, Average, Count and the Zoom level
Scroll bars	Right and bottom	Move around the spreadsheet
Cell grid	Large centre area	The main working area — enter all your data here

Practice 1.4: Sheet tabs

Practice · 3 of 4

GOAL

Rename a worksheet using its tab at the bottom of the screen.

1 Right-click the sheet tab at the bottom.

2 Click **Rename**.

3 Type **My Sheet**. Press **Enter**.

YOU SHOULD SEE

- The tab now says My Sheet
- Your name is still in B3
- Only the tab name changed

The Excel Ribbon — key tabs

1.5 • Theory

Home

Formatting, font, alignment, number format, cell styles — the most-used tab

Insert

Charts, tables, pictures, shapes, PivotTables

Page Layout

Margins, orientation, print area, gridlines, headings

Formulas

Insert functions, named ranges, formula auditing tools

Data

Sort, filter, import data, remove duplicates, data validation

Review

Spelling check, comments, protect a sheet or workbook

View

Freeze panes, split, zoom, arrange windows

Home is the most-used tab — it holds everything for everyday formatting.

Practice 1.5: Ribbon tabs

Practice · 4 of 4

GOAL

Explore the Ribbon, then show your work to the teacher.

1 Click the **Insert** tab. Look at the options.

2 Click the **Home** tab to return.

3 Show your screen to the teacher.

TEACHER CHECK

- Name Box shows B3
- Sheet tab renamed to My Sheet
- Your name is visible in cell B3

Unit 1 — Key takeaways

- 1.1** Excel is a spreadsheet program for numbers, data, calculations and charts.
- 1.2** Open Excel from the Start menu, from a .xlsx file, or from the Start Screen.
- 1.3** Key terms: workbook, worksheet, cell, row, column, range, formula.
- 1.4** Main interface parts: Title Bar, Ribbon, Name Box, Formula Bar, sheet tabs.
- 1.5** The Ribbon has 7 key tabs — Home is the most-used for everyday formatting.